

GETTING OFF THE flight at Changsha Huanghua International Airport in early 2007 was an experience for Vineet Agrawal. The CEO of Wipro Consumer Care & Lighting had gone to China with his A-team to close the buyout of Unza Holdings, a manufacturer of personal care products with plants across China and Southeast Asia. It was Agrawal's first touchdown at Changsha, one of the world's busiest airports, and he remembers it vividly: clad in a business suit, he felt out of place among the locals wearing Bermuda shorts.

Agrawal could not locate anyone who spoke English. No interpreter either. Hailing a taxi, he showed the driver a slip of paper with his destination's address in Chinese. The driver stared at it blankly. Things looked ominous. "Unza," Agrawal said. The cabbie's face lit up, and he gestured to Agrawal's party to hop in. "We figured it was a good company since the driver knew it. That was a small thing, but it mattered," he recalls.

Wipro Consumer Care & Lighting, a division of Wipro Enterprises, was new to the foreign buyouts game. But the noughties was when Wipro's competitors, such as Godrej and Marico, were picking up companies abroad. For Wipro Consumer, then a ₹600-crore entity, Unza would be the first. By early June that year, Unza was in the bag for \$246 million (then ₹1,010 crore).

Wipro Consumer Care & Lighting was born in 2013, when parent Wipro Ltd, the infotech giant, spun it off into an unlisted company called Wipro Enterprises, along with infrastructure engineering and medical di-

agnostic products and services. Fast-forward 10 years: For 2022-23, Wipro Consumer reported revenues of ₹10,014 crore, popping up in India's big-league of fast-moving consumer goods companies such as market leader Hindustan Unilever (₹61,092 crore), Adani Wilmar, ITC (non-cigarette FMCG), Nestlé India, Britannia, Dabur, and Marico (which Wipro has just overtaken). Wipro Consumer's FMCG business is almost evenly split between domestic and international markets, with Unza giving it a strong presence in Southeast Asia.

So what's the secret sauce?

Wipro Founding Chairman Azim Premji tells *Business Today*, "What makes us stand apart is our hunger for growth and the strategic growth steps that we have taken. We have built strong brands... and our teams have also completed some successful acquisitions, but more than just acquiring the brands, we have significantly grown most of them."

Wipro's next big bet: the spices business and snacks.

"This confidence in ensuring the success of our brands acquired demonstrates our adaptability and readiness to pursue new avenues for sustainable growth," says Premji.

Let's get back to Agrawal. He joined Wipro Ltd in 1985 as a trainee and has grown with it, from its entry into information technology to building the FMCG portfolio. Even when he became CEO of the consumer business in 2003, the product portfolio was remarkably different: *vanaspati*, a leather exports business, Milk and Roses toilet soap, baby products, and Shikakai soap. Lighting was a small component, and Santoor, with revenues of ₹150 crore, accounted for half of Wipro Consumer's top

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“We are looking to expand into categories from an India point of view. The size and scale in foods is very different from, say, soaps, which is a ₹27,000-crore market. The spices [business] alone is ₹70,000 crore, and snacks is another ₹75,000 crore”

VINEET AGRAWAL

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